

# SHIPPING WATCH

**POLESTAR INSIGHTS**

REPORTING PERIOD: 18 MAY 2026 - 24 MAY 2026

FAST FACTS

REPORTING PERIOD

18 May - 24 May 2026

RECORDS IN WINDOW

14

HIGHEST SEVERITY

Moderate

MAIN AFFECTED CHOKEPOINT (30D)

Straits of Hormuz

194 records

VESSEL ATTACKS / SEIZURES (30D)

26

PIRACY / ARMED ROBBERY (30D)

2

Latest record in window: 22 May 2026

LATEST SIGNIFICANT INCIDENT

22 May 2026

Frontline cashes in on ageing suezmax pair

CHOKEPOINT / ROUTE READ

The 30-day picture is led by Straits of Hormuz, which carries 194 qualifying records and a highest severity of extreme. Arabian / Persian Gulf follows with 4 records.

Inside the weekly briefing window, 6 records pointed at transit, diversion or advisory pressure - a tighter view of what shippers actually felt across the cycle.

Watch for new naval advisories on Straits of Hormuz, any war-risk premium adjustments and operator commentary on rerouting. Those are the early indicators of escalation; commercial freight rates lag them by days.

CHOKEPOINT WATCH, LAST 30 DAYS (25 APR - 24 MAY 2026)

| CHOKEPOINT             | RECORDS | HIGHEST SEV | LATEST      | OPERATIONAL READ                                                                                                                                          |
|------------------------|---------|-------------|-------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Straits of Hormuz      | 194     | EXTREME     | 22 May 2026 | Reporting was led by "Iran proposes permanent toll for Straits of Hormuz shipping", with 194 qualifying records over the last 30 days.                    |
| Gulf of Oman           | 2       | EXTREME     | 15 May 2026 | Reporting was led by "Two India-Bound LPG Tankers Clear Hormuz in Dark Mode", with 2 qualifying records over the last 30 days.                            |
| Arabian / Persian Gulf | 4       | EXTREME     | 07 May 2026 | Reporting was led by "Straits of Hormuz traffic drops to 14 ships, with most leaving Persian Gulf: CAS", with 4 qualifying records over the last 30 days. |
| Red Sea                | 1       | LOW         | 07 May 2026 | Activity here was anchored by a single entry, "Drewry: Suez Canal Containership Crossings Recover", over the last 30 days.                                |
| Bab el-Mandeb          | 1       | EXTREME     | 01 May 2026 | Low-confidence reporting only; no validated maritime advisory or credible operational incident identified in the last 30 days.                            |
| Malacca Strait         | 0       | -           | -           | Quiet over the last 30 days; no qualifying activity on file.                                                                                              |

## VESSEL THREAT AND PIRACY READ

Hostile activity against vessels over the last 30 days runs to 12 records, of which 26 are an attack or seizure rather than a softer boarding or approach. The lead entry is "UKMTO Reports Vessel Seized by Unauthorized Personnel Near Strait of Hormuz - News and Statistics - IndexBox". Piracy and armed-robbery reporting carries 2 records across the same window, with "Armed robbers board bulk carrier in Singapore Strait" as the lead entry.

Inside the weekly briefing cycle itself, no fresh vessel-side or piracy records were filed; the read leans on the trailing 30-day picture.

Track maritime advisories, naval-force statements and any movement in war-risk or P&I premiums on affected routes. Those are the cleanest early indicators that hostile activity is firming or easing.

## VESSEL ATTACKS, LAST 30 DAYS (25 APR - 24 MAY 2026)

| DATE        | ACT    | TITLE                                                                                                                | SEVERITY |
|-------------|--------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 15 May 2026 | Seized | 11 Pakistanis, 20 Iranians aboard US-seized vessels repatriated, says DPM Dar                                        | EXTREME  |
| 15 May 2026 | Seized | UKMTO Reports Vessel Seized by Unauthorized Personnel Near Strait of Hormuz - News and Statistics - IndexBox         | EXTREME  |
| 14 May 2026 | Seized | Vessel seized off UAE coast, moved toward Iranian waters, UKMTO says - Caliber.Az                                    | LOW      |
| 14 May 2026 | Seized | Vessel seized off UAE coast, headed toward Iranian waters: UK maritime agency - Anadolu Ajans                        | LOW      |
| 14 May 2026 | Seized | Vessel seized off UAE coast by unauthorized individuals now heading toward Iranian waters - The New Voice of Ukraine | LOW      |
| 14 May 2026 | Seized | Vessel seized off UAE and heading toward Iranian waters: UKMTO - The New Arab                                        | LOW      |
| 14 May 2026 | Seized | UKMTO says Honduran-flagged vessel seized by Iran near UAE - upi.com                                                 | LOW      |
| 14 May 2026 | Seized | Hormuz Crisis: Vessel Seized Off UAE Heading to Iran - Deccan Herald                                                 | EXTREME  |
| 14 May 2026 | Seized | Vessel seized off UAE coast headed for Iranian waters: UK agency - Yeni Safak English                                | LOW      |
| 11 May 2026 | Attack | UKMTO reports vessel attack on bulk carrier off Doha - Safety4Sea                                                    | LOW      |
| 07 May 2026 | Attack | Iran claims missile strike on US naval units near Strait of Hormuz after tanker attack by America                    | EXTREME  |
| 06 May 2026 | Attack | Cargo vessel struck by projectile at Strait of Hormuz, UKMTO says - ThePrint                                         | LOW      |

## PIRACY AND ARMED ROBBERY, LAST 30 DAYS (25 APR - 24 MAY 2026)

| DATE        | ACT      | TITLE                                                                 | SEVERITY |
|-------------|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 05 May 2026 | Boarding | Armed robbers board bulk carrier in Singapore Strait                  | MODERATE |
| 27 Apr 2026 | Piracy   | Somalia piracy: Another vessel seized as threat level increased - BBC | MODERATE |

## COMMERCIAL IMPACT ON SHIPPING

No port, freight, insurance or commercial-shipping disruption records reached the file in the weekly window. Pure market commentary - newbuild orders, vessel S&P, fleet finance, earnings, share-price moves - is intentionally excluded from this section, so a blank cycle here means the operational disruption signal was genuinely quiet rather than under-reported.

Watch for fresh port advisories, schedule slippage out of the major box and tanker hubs, and any insurance-premium adjustments tied to specific routes. Those are the next signals that operational commercial pressure is firming.

## RECORDS

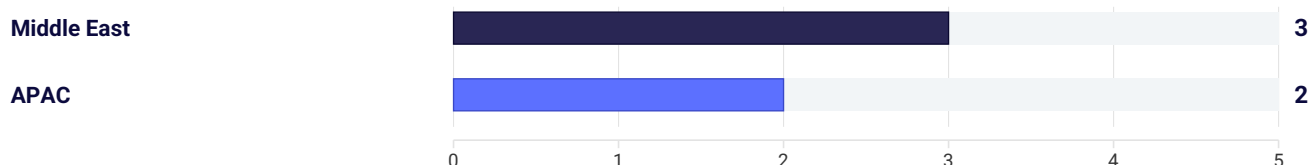
*No port, freight, insurance or commercial-shipping disruption records in the weekly window.*

## REGIONAL AND COUNTRY VIEW

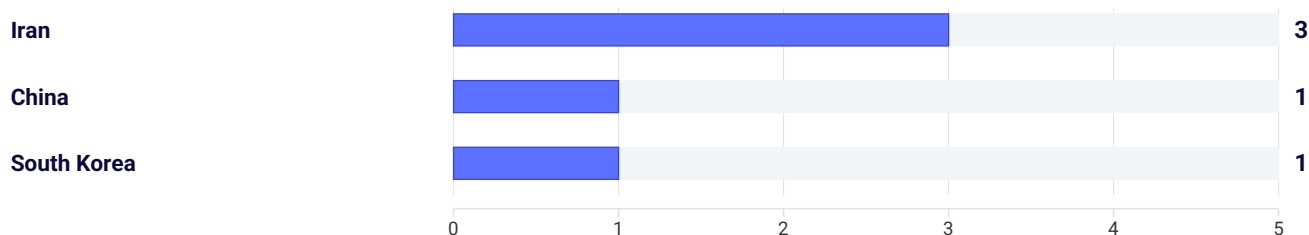
Across the weekly briefing window, Middle East carries the heavier share with 3 records against 2 for APAC. At country level the cycle is led by Iran (3), China (1) and South Korea (1).

A further 9 records could not be tied to a confirmed incident country and are excluded from the country chart to avoid distortion.

## RECORDS BY REGION



## RECORDS BY COUNTRY



## WHAT MATTERS

The cycle's centre of gravity is Strait of Hormuz, which carries 194 qualifying records ahead of Arabian / Persian Gulf on 4. That matters for routing decisions because every additional advisory tightens transit-time variance and feeds straight into vessel scheduling and bunker planning for any operator with exposure to the region.

Hostile activity against vessels still anchors the risk picture, with 26 attack or seizure records and 2 piracy or armed-robbery entries on file over the trailing 30 days (25 Apr - 24 May 2026). Any operator running through the affected lanes should be reviewing crew-change locations, war-risk and P&I premium exposure, and the threshold at which their advisory partners would recommend re-routing.

Regionally the weekly window leaned on Middle East; country-level concentration is set out in the chart below.

## IMPLICATIONS FOR BUSINESS

- Run a live review of vessel scheduling, port-call sequencing and bunker planning against the latest advisories for Strait of Hormuz.
- Size war-risk and P&I exposure now - premium adjustments typically land one to two cycles after the operational signal firms.
- Pre-position alternative routings and skip-call options on affected strings; brief commercial teams on demurrage and schedule-reliability risk.
- Re-examine crew-change locations on voyages transiting the affected lanes; shift to safer ports where supported.
- Confirm naval-escort or convoy options with advisory partners for the highest-risk strings.
- Write flexibility clauses into near-term lifting contracts - a single port closure or war-risk move can pull surcharges across a lane within days.

## WATCH NEXT

- Fresh naval and maritime advisories on Strait of Hormuz: leading signal for where pressure is firming.
- UKMTO, IMB and coalition-force bulletins: move ahead of headline freight rates.
- War-risk and P&I premium movement on affected lanes: cleanest confirmation that the operational signal has firmed commercially.
- Operator decisions to divert or skip a port call: trigger schedule-reliability and demurrage review.
- Escalation in naval-escort or convoy posture: signal that advisory partners are sizing up the threat.
- Crew-change advisories and flag-state guidance updates: re-examine manning-hub plans on transiting voyages.
- Hostile-area underwriting extended to adjacent waters: clearest sign the threat perimeter is widening, not easing.

## POLESTAR VIEW

Our read on the cycle is that the underlying maritime security picture remains structurally elevated even when the weekly file looks quieter than the trailing 30 days. Strait of Hormuz continues to set the tempo, and operators should be planning against a "quiet weeks, sharp incidents" cadence rather than a sustained easing.

For commercial decisions, the practical implication is that routing, port-call sequencing and crew-change planning should be treated as live risk decisions every cycle - not annual reviews. War-risk and P&I premium movement remains the cleanest single signal that the operational picture is firming; reliability indices and headline freight rates lag it.

Geographically the pressure this cycle sat with Middle East. We expect the same lanes and corridors to set the tempo through the next reporting window unless a fresh naval-force posture change or a credible diplomatic move on the underlying conflicts disrupts the pattern.

## RELATED INCIDENTS

| DATE        | ISSUE           | TITLE                                                                                               | SEVERITY |
|-------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 22 May 2026 | Chokepoint risk | Strait of Hormuz closure risks greatest global energy supply shock in decades, Wood Mackenzie warns | MODERATE |
| 22 May 2026 | Chokepoint risk | Iran proposes permanent toll for Strait of Hormuz shipping                                          | LOW      |
| 21 May 2026 | Chokepoint risk | First coordinated VLCC transits through Hormuz raise cautious hopes of a thaw                       | LOW      |
| 21 May 2026 | Chokepoint risk | Strait of Hormuz disruption helps drive 8% rise in Panama Canal transits                            | LOW      |
| 20 May 2026 | Chokepoint risk | FM Cho says probe into Hormuz Strait vessel attack in final stage                                   | LOW      |

| DATE        | ISSUE                        | TITLE                                                             | SEVERITY |
|-------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 18 May 2026 | Chokepoint risk              | Iran to unveil Strait of Hormuz traffic plans, will collect tolls | LOW      |
| 22 May 2026 | Insurance / freight pressure | Freight rate recovery 'more about demand than blanked sailings'   | LOW      |

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